When the machine doesn’t understand you

How AI is changing the way we speak English

Global English · essay presentation

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HOW I GOT TO THE TOPIC

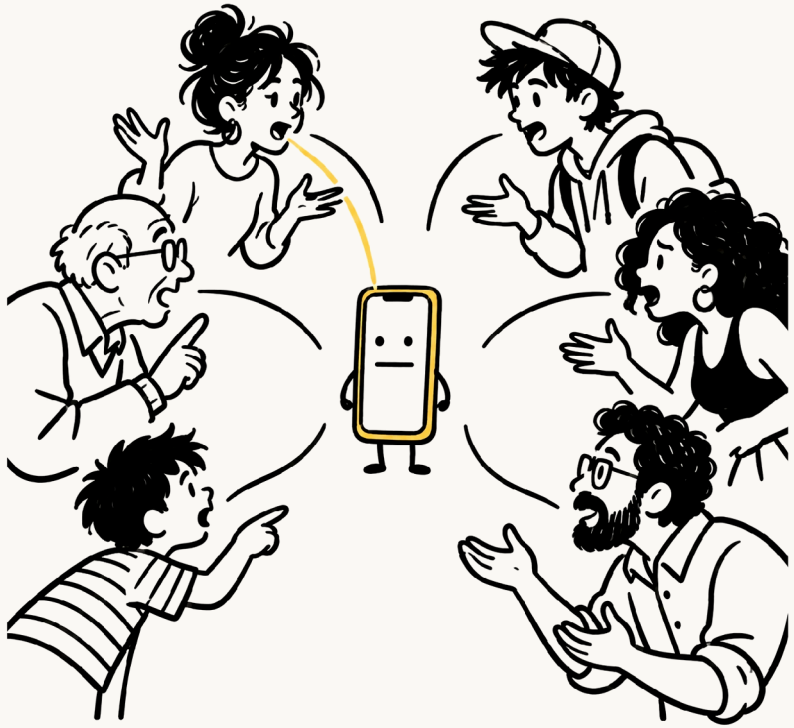
It started with my own voice.

I am German, but I speak a strong Bavarian dialect. When I use voice-to-text, my phone often writes nonsense. For example:

> I SAY **“I hob koa Zeit”** Bavarian for “I have no time”
>
> PHONE WRITES ~~“I hope Korea”~~

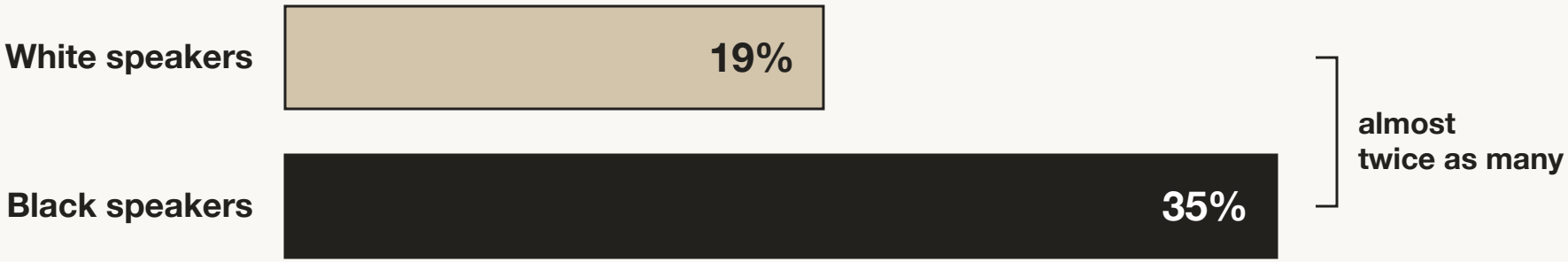
The software is not broken. I just don’t sound like the people it learned from.

So I asked myself: if this happens to me in German — what happens to English speakers with an accent?



THE EVIDENCE

It is not just a feeling.

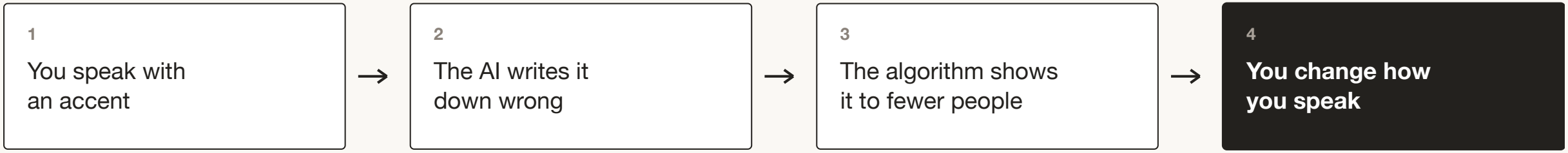


word error rate — how often the software writes down the wrong word

Stanford University, published in *PNAS* (2020). The researchers tested five speech recognition systems — Amazon, Apple, Google, IBM and Microsoft — with the same sentences. Non-native speakers run into the same wall.

WHY THIS CHANGES THE LANGUAGE

The machine does not just listen. It decides.



and the machine never had to change at all

TikTok and YouTube read your video through automatic captions. If the caption is wrong, fewer people ever see you — and creators are already changing their pronunciation to fix that.

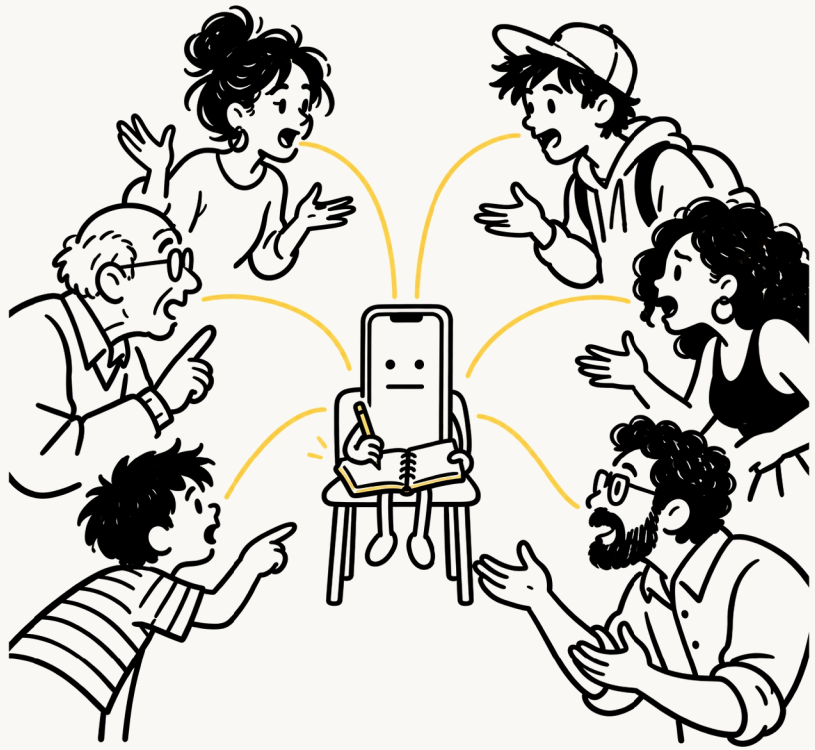
MY ARGUMENT

AI should learn our accents. Not the other way around.

1. Where the idea came from — **my own voice**
2. What **Standard English Ideology** means: one way of speaking counts as the correct one
3. The **Stanford study** — and what it means for anyone with an accent
4. What this does to people online — **fewer views, less money**
5. What I think has to change — **better training data**

If you do not sound standard, fewer people see you.

Software created a language problem.



A few days ago, I was trying to use a voice-to-text feature on my phone, but it produced a lot of mistakes. Since I often speak German with a Bavarian dialect, the AI simply struggled to understand me. This everyday situation made me think about our course topic and how technology handles the English language. AI and algorithms are becoming more and more present in our daily lives—whether you like it or not. But I realized that these tools do not just passively transcribe what we say; they are actually starting to change how people speak English. Because algorithms often only understand one specific standard, users are forced to adapt their voices to the machine. In this essay, I want to discuss how AI enforces “Standard English Ideology” and how this changes the power dynamics of modern communication.

While thinking about my own experience, I noticed that modern technology perfectly shows how this ideology works in the real world today. When we look at auto-caption tools or speech recognition, we can see a clear power dynamic. Most of these AI models are trained on data from white, standard American English speakers. For example, a 2020 study from Stanford University tested speech recognition systems from large tech companies. The researchers found that the software made significantly more mistakes when Black people were speaking compared to white speakers. The same issue applies to non-native speakers from all over the world. Because they have an accent, the software simply fails to transcribe their words correctly.

This creates a strict power imbalance on platforms like TikTok or YouTube. These platforms use automatic transcriptions to understand what a video is about and to show it to the right audience. If the algorithm cannot understand your accent, your content might not reach many people, which means you can lose views and even income. Because of this disadvantage, we can see a real shift in the English language: many creators are actually starting to change their pronunciation. They try to sound more like the standard just to be understood by the machine.

In conclusion, Standard English Ideology is built directly into the software we use every day, and it is actively changing how people speak globally. If you do not fit the linguistic standard, you lose visibility online. Since English is an international language, AI must be trained to understand diverse accents, instead of forcing everyone to adapt to one single standard.